# WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

*Connecting International Capital*

# ARUBA

Americas

*Information current as of November 2026*

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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## WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

### KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

| Location / Region | Strategic Importance | Priority Sectors |
|---|---|---|
| Oranjestad | Capital and seat of government, focal point for cruise calls and main commercial and financial centre of this autonomous country within the Kingdom of the Netherlands | Financial and professional services, retail, cruise tourism, real estate |
| Palm Beach and Eagle Beach (north-west coast) | Core hotel corridor and engine of a tourism economy that drew a record 1.52 million stay-over visitors in 2025, with new luxury openings such as The St. Regis Aruba and JOIA Aruba by Iberostar | Hotels and resorts, hospitality services, leisure and food and beverage |
| San Nicolas and the former Lago refinery site (south-east) | Historic refinery site to be dismantled and repurposed, with Dutch technical support and international tenders, as a hub for clean energy, maritime innovation and circular industries | Renewable energy, maritime, circular economy, housing, culture and tourism |
| Baby Beach / south-east coast | Emerging leisure destination anchored by Secrets Baby Beach Aruba, the island's first Hyatt Inclusive Collection resort, spreading tourism activity beyond the north-west | Resort development, eco- and niche tourism, local services |
| Barcadera | One of Aruba's two Free Zone locations, serving the island's import-led supply chain and regional distribution | Logistics, warehousing, re-export and light industry |
| Queen Beatrix International Airport | Main gateway with nonstop links to North America, Europe and Latin America, being modernised under the multi-phase Gateway 2030 programme | Aviation services, airport retail, construction |
| Free Zone Aruba (Oranjestad and Barcadera) | Designated zones where qualifying companies pay 2% profit tax on qualifying income | Trading, distribution, logistics and qualifying services |

### INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Aruba Investment Agency (ARINA), within the Department of Economic Affairs, Commerce and Industry, offers free sector intelligence, a single point of contact and fast-track handling of licences and permits
- Government 'Promising Sectors' strategy prioritising tourism value-added, the knowledge economy, agriculture, logistics, circular economy and creative industries

- Free Zone Aruba (Oranjestad and Barcadera) offering a 2% profit tax rate on qualifying income for trading, distribution and qualifying services, with local-market sales requiring approval
- Aruban florin fixed at Afl. 1.79 = $1.00 since 1986, managed by the Centrale Bank van Aruba; payments abroad carry a 1.3% foreign exchange commission and a general licence regime applies to foreign account holders
- Tourism investment aligned with the high-value, low-impact model and source-market diversification recommended by the IMF, supported by Aruba Tourism Authority market data
- Tender-based entry into the San Nicolas refinery-site redevelopment and utility projects run by WEB Aruba, including grid modernisation and energy storage
- Hotel, resort and real-estate development through licensing procedures coordinated with ARINA and the relevant ministries

### MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Aruba enters late 2026 on the back of one of the strongest recoveries in the Caribbean. The Centrale Bank van Aruba (CBA) estimates real GDP growth of 6.3% in 2025, following 8.9% in 2023 and 7.6% in 2024, and forecasts a further 3.7% in 2026 as growth normalises. Stay-over arrivals reached a record 1,515,102 in 2025 (+6.6%) and rose 8.9% year-on-year in the first quarter of 2026. Inflation averaged just 0.1% in 2025 and was 2.4% in June 2026, in line with a 2.4% forecast for the year. Public finances have been transformed: central government debt has fallen from 116.3% of GDP in 2020 to around 61% in early 2026, the first quarter of 2026 delivered a budget surplus of 1.5% of GDP, and all three major rating agencies rate Aruba investment grade following Fitch's upgrade in March 2025. International reserves reached Afl. 5.32 billion (about $3 billion) in May 2026, covering roughly ten months of foreign payments, and the IMF projects a current account surplus of about 7.8% of GDP for 2025.

Aruba's main structural challenge is the concentration of its economy on tourism and on the North American market, which supplied 73.6% of stay-over visitors in June 2026. This concentration has been managed well: a fixed florin peg, reserves of more than 174% of the IMF adequacy benchmark, a well-capitalised banking system and a strengthened fiscal framework provide substantial buffers against external shocks. The Consensus Kingdom Act on sustainable public finances, approved by the Kingdom Council of Ministers in March 2026 and now with the Council of State, will give Aruba access to Dutch borrowing terms and a lower rate on pandemic-era loans, freeing resources for investment. Diversification is gathering pace through the 'Promising Sectors' strategy, the repurposing of the former Lago refinery site with a €50 million Dutch contribution to grid and clean-energy infrastructure, a 35 MW/70 MWh battery storage project with WEB Aruba, growth in South American arrivals and the resumption of flights to Venezuela in July 2026 after seven years, each creating openings for investors.

## INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

### KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Concentration on tourism and the US market | Tourism drives growth and North America supplied 73.6% of stay-over visitors in June 2026, so performance tracks US travel demand | Strong buffers cushion swings; diversification into Latin American markets, niche tourism and the Promising Sectors offers early-mover opportunities |
| Infrastructure, housing and labour capacity | The IMF notes that strong tourism demand is straining infrastructure, labour markets and housing affordability | Investment in housing, utilities, airport and workforce solutions is a government priority and an opening for private partners |
| Small, import-dependent market | Goods imports of about $1.5 billion in 2023 compare with goods exports of about $111 million, with the US supplying around half of imports | Use the Free Zone for regional distribution, and target import-substitution niches such as agriculture and renewable energy |
| Foreign exchange commission and licensing | A 1.3% commission applies to payments abroad and transfers to non-resident accounts, adding to transaction costs | The florin's fixed peg to the dollar since 1986 removes currency risk; structure flows with local banks and the CBA's general licence for foreign account holders |
| Public investment delivery and Kingdom fiscal supervision | Budgets are overseen by the College Aruba financieel toezicht (CAft), which has noted delays in establishing a planned investment fund | Debt is falling and fiscal surpluses are being recorded; investors in public-private projects can align with the multi-year investment agenda and engage early on |

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| | | tenders |
| Climate exposure | As a small island, Aruba faces sea-level rise and extreme-weather risks to coastal infrastructure | Adaptation planning is being built into the fiscal framework, creating opportunities in resilient construction, water and renewable energy |
| Regional geopolitical context | Aruba lies close to Venezuela, where political tensions led to a seven-year suspension of flights from 2019 | Phased resumption of commercial flights from July 2026 opens prospects for trade and tourism; monitor developments in routine planning |

### INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Aruba's risk profile is that of a stable, investment-grade island economy with strong institutions, a currency fixed to the US dollar since 1986 and its constitutional place within the Kingdom of the Netherlands. Public debt has fallen by more than half relative to GDP since 2020, budgets are in surplus, reserves cover around ten months of foreign payments and the banking sector is well capitalised and liquid. The principal consideration for investors is the economy's reliance on tourism and the US source market; this is offset by deep buffers, a record of rapid recovery and an active diversification agenda backed by Dutch support for the energy transition. Practical points include the 1.3% foreign exchange commission, the pace of public-investment delivery and capacity constraints in housing and labour, all of which can be built into project planning. With the Kingdom Act on sustainable public finances set to lower borrowing costs, the fiscal outlook continues to strengthen.

### MARKET ACCESS

Aruba is an autonomous constituent country of the Kingdom of the Netherlands; it is not part of the EU but is associated with it as an Overseas Country and Territory (OCT), giving its goods preferential access to the EU market, and its nationals hold Dutch and therefore EU citizenship. It participates in the WTO through the Kingdom of the Netherlands. Trade is dominated by imports, with the US supplying around 50% and the Netherlands around 13% in 2023, while goods exports go mainly to Colombia, the US and Curaçao. Aruba's true export is services: tourism earnings, supported by nonstop air links to more than a dozen US gateways as well as Canada, Europe and Latin America, and cruise calls. Proximity to South America, restored air links to Venezuela and the Free Zone position Aruba as a compact hub for regional distribution and services.

## WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

### INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Office of the Prime Minister (Mike Eman) | Leads economic policy, the refinery-site redevelopment and relations with the Netherlands and Venezuela | Primary reference point for Aruba's strategic and investment priorities |
| Aruba Investment Agency (ARINA) / Department of Economic Affairs, Commerce and Industry | National investment promotion body and single point of contact for foreign investors | Standard first point of contact for market entry, permits and Promising Sectors opportunities |
| Centrale Bank van Aruba (CBA) | Maintains the florin peg, manages reserves and foreign exchange regulation, and supervises banks | Relevant for foreign exchange licensing, banking and financial-sector entry |
| Ministry of Finance and the College Aruba financieel toezicht (CAft) | Set and supervise the budget, debt strategy and public investment agenda under the Kingdom framework | Relevant for public-private partnerships and government-backed projects |
| Aruba Tourism Authority (A.T.A.) | Markets the destination and publishes monthly visitor data by source market | Essential partner for hospitality, airlift and tourism-product investment |
| WEB Aruba (Water- en Energiebedrijf Aruba) | State water and power producer driving the transition to wind, solar and storage | Key counterpart for energy, storage and utility investment |
| Free Zone Aruba and Aruba Airport Authority | Operate the Free Zone regime and the Queen Beatrix International Airport | Relevant for logistics, distribution and |

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| | Gateway 2030 expansion | aviation-related investment |

## CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Aruba Chamber of Commerce and Industry is the main business registry and liaison body and holds regular meetings with the Prime Minister, while the Aruba Trade & Industry Association (ATIA) and the Aruba Hotel and Tourism Association (AHATA) represent the commercial and hospitality sectors. ARINA hosts investor engagement and facilitates introductions to government and private partners. Dutch government channels, including the Kingdom Council of Ministers and the energy-transition support for San Nicolas, are an important route into larger public projects, and Aruba's OCT association links it to EU cooperation programmes. Major international hotel groups and utility partners such as Wärtsilä are active on the island and are useful sources of practical intelligence.

## INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Aruba suits investors seeking a stable, dollar-linked, investment-grade jurisdiction within the Kingdom of the Netherlands: hotel, resort and real-estate developers targeting high-value, low-impact tourism; renewable energy, storage and water investors aligned with WEB Aruba's transition and the San Nicolas redevelopment; logistics and distribution businesses using the Free Zone at Oranjestad and Barcadera; and housing, construction and infrastructure investors addressing capacity needs identified by the IMF. Knowledge-economy, agri-tech and creative-industry ventures can benefit from the government's Promising Sectors focus, and Latin American investors may find Aruba a convenient gateway to Kingdom and EU-linked markets.

## FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage ARINA and map Promising Sectors opportunities
Open dialogue with the Aruba Investment Agency to identify sector priorities, available sites and fast-track permitting for your project.

STEP 2: Track the San Nicolas refinery-site redevelopment tenders
Follow the governance structure and international tenders being prepared with Dutch support for clean energy, maritime and circular-industry uses.

STEP 3: Structure cross-border flows around the florin peg and FX regime
Work with local banks and advisers to factor in the 1.3% foreign exchange commission and use the CBA's general licence where it applies.

STEP 4: Assess Free Zone and logistics options
Evaluate the 2% Free Zone regime at Oranjestad or Barcadera for trading, distribution and qualifying services aimed at regional markets.

STEP 5: Align with energy-transition and infrastructure partners
Engage WEB Aruba, the Airport Authority and the Ministry of Finance on storage, grid, housing and airport projects within the multi-year investment agenda.